

One-Pager: Media Management

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Common Media Items

In top-down RPGs like my game, it is important that the player can embody the character that they play. According to an edited chapter of *From Pixels to Play – The Art and Science of Video Games* by game designer Remi Poivet, “As players navigate rich virtual environments, their avatars act as psychological, cultural, and narrative anchors.” [1]. Through gameplay, this is expressed through the player gaining new abilities along with the character as they both overcome challenges.

Similarly, this is commonly expressed through media items by incorporating art and animations that make the character’s actions clear for the player to see and understand. In addition to this, dialogue text and short cinematics are included to allow the character to express themselves or respond to other portions of the narrative, ultimately allowing the player to empathize with them.

Integration Strategies

Animation

Animation is a useful tool for making movements and actions made by the player’s character and enemies clear. They can also add personality and appeal to a character, allowing players to identify with them further.

One famous example of this is in *Undertale* [2], where the animation principles timing and motion, anticipation, and exaggeration are used to make enemy attacks clear to players. The game also allows players to appeal to enemies’ personalities to grant them mercy. To support this system, the game uses principles of staging and appeal to make the personality traits of enemies clear. Ultimately, *Undertale* successfully utilizes animation principles to support its unique gameplay and characters.

However, overuse of animation can lead to scope creep. Animation can also contrast with the style of the game or obscure readability if not correctly implemented. For these reasons, I can limit implementation of animation to moments in my game where animation would improve the personality of the characters or readability of movements. These can include walk cycles, idle animations, item receive animations and attack animations. This way, the player has visual feedback for the actions they take while being able to further identify with their character.

Dialogue

Dialogue in games like *Undertale* is a form of media that can be used along with animation to further express a character’s personality and can organically inform players of their next objective.

However, objective-based dialogue should be implemented carefully, as according to game writer Susan in an article, “Unless players can easily replay lines of dialogue, the reality is if they miss a line, they’ve missed it. And if the player realizes they’ve missed something important, they’ll be annoyed” [3]. When incorporating dialogue, it is important to consider players that want to learn more about the story and the world as well as those who wish to engage solely with the gameplay.

For these reasons, I plan to incorporate dialogue into my game as one method for the player to keep track of their objective, while also placing this information in a retrievable place, such as a journal the player character keeps. This approach allows dialogue to enhance the experience of those interested in the narrative and the world while not impeding the experience of those primarily interested in gameplay.

[1] <https://www.intechopen.com/online-first/1221056>

[2] Toby Fox. (2016). Undertale. Computer software.

[3] <https://www.thenarrativedept.com/blog/game-script>

AI: N/A